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John Pizzarelli

Guitarist/vocalist John Pizzarelli Jr. was born on April 6, 1960 in Paterson, NJ. He grew up surrounded by jazz but also drew on influences from the popular music of the day. John was performing in duo situations with his father, Bucky, by 1980, later joining the Tony Monte Trio, and broadcasting over WNEW in New York. His prowess on the seven string guitar and relaxed vocal style have made him one of today's most sought-after jazz performers and recording artists. He currently leads a trio with his brother Martin on bass and Ray Kennedy on piano.

John was interviewed in New York on January 29, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in Manhattan and I'm very pleased to have John Pizzarelli with me today.

JP: It's nice to be here.

MR: Welcome. I have a feeling that most of the bios that will be done on you and have been done on you kind of have that "comes from a musical family," right?

JP: Right. They always start there. Why did a guy like you decide to play jazz instead of rock & roll is another biggie.

MR: Right.

JP: And growing up with a father in the business.

MR: Your gig at The Regency in town, you're bringing in just about everyone in your family?

JP: Yeah, my trio, Ray Kennedy on piano, and my brother Martin on bass, my younger brother, and my wife is singing with me, and also my father is playing. So we bring them on at different times in the show. They're not there the whole time. But Jess comes up somewhere at the beginning, sings three songs, goes off, we play a little more, and then near the end we bring up my dad.

MR: Well you grew up in a time when you had a heck of a lot of musical influences to choose from, in addition to your father and so forth. What made you gravitate from one thing to the next. Did you latch on to something before jazz?

JP: Oh yeah. I think the sound of The Beatles was in our house from when I was born. I was born April 6, 1960, so when I was about four my sisters had all those Beatle records. That stuff, that sound. And I remember — clearly remember — singing along with those records at a very young age. And I remember a little later on, I was six or seven, my father bringing the banjo down, the tenor banjo downstairs because it was his father's, and my father's uncles, Pete and Bobby Domenick, were banjo players and guitar

players. And he said, "you're going to go to Victor's House of Music in Ridgewood and you're going to play, they'll give you some banjo lessons." Cool. So I went down, we went through the book, and at the end of the lesson he'd go, "okay today we're going to learn 'Bye Bye Blues." And he'd go [scats], "Put your fingers here," and we'd go through the songs. So that was about a year or two of that. Maybe just a year, I don't remember how long it was. And so — that's the summer of '66, '67. And I played for a year or two, and then I put it down for a while and then I studied with Pete, the older brother, who was the most accomplished musician I've ever known, who was just phenomenal. And he was the oldest brother of all my father's uncles and aunts. And he stayed home, worked and did club dates on the weekends but he was a fabulous banjo — I mean remarkable. And my father — he was really a father to my father. Even though my father had a father who was a store owner, a big guy. Pete was the guy. And I'd play with Pete and watch him play with my dad, and I had a lot of that going on. This hand has been doing that for a long, long time. And so I just played, and then I put that down too, I mean I was now ten. And then shortly after that, there were always guitars on the couch at our house, so I'd pick up the guitar and start playing along to records. So Elton John records, because I discovered the books with the dots.

MR: Tabletures?

JP: Yeah. And so there were the chords, now see? And it works with the records. So I'd play along with records. And gravitated toward learning Peter Frampton solos and all that, that went along with that. I mean my father had amps and guitars, so I was the guy. "Come on over, we've got the equipment." Plugging everything into one amplifier, the whole band came out. And so along the way my father said, "Well okay" actually he tells it, which is strange, is that there was a trombone player a couple of towns over who wanted to play "Spain" like at a talent show at his high school. So we had this record and so I was like okay, so I had to go [scats], that was the fastest thing I'd ever played in my life [scats]. So it was a big deal. So I learned this thing and my father was like amazed I guess. And I can imagine, that out of the clear blue sky we're playing "Spain." And so he went okay — here's a Django Reinhardt record. Listen to "Rose Room." And here's this guy going [scats]. Jeez. Okay. Well I'll try some of that. And then we started in with the George Barnes-Bucky Pizzarelli records. And he'd say, "Why don't you listen to George?" And I'd start to learn George's parts, and we'd play them around the house. And so the jazz vocabulary was making its way into my head. And I would go, whenever he'd play a concert somewhere I'd go and play "Honeysuckle Rose" at the end of the concert with him, because I knew George's part and I could play his solo pretty poorly, so, hence, that was my thing. And then he taught me "Chicken a la Swing" that Carl Kress/Dick

McDonough duet and I played the second part. That was sort of a rite of passage for the Pizzarellis. Because Mary had learned it previously when she was fifteen. A very hip family.

MR: I guess so.

JP: I went to Florida once and I was jamming with Jack Petersen, a great guitar player down there. And he'd say, "What do you want to play?" And I said, "I want to play "Chicken a la Swing," and he knew the first part. And I said how many guys are jamming "Chicken a la Swing?" Everybody else would call like "Monk's Mood." No we were playing "Chicken a la Swing." So there was all this guitar stuff going on, and that's how the guitar all started.

MR: I mean I was hearing Ray Conniff when I grew up. Wow.

JP: It was fun. I think, and then I started to play, I met a kid at this day camp I was working at. Because the only other job I ever had was a day camp counselor. And I like working with kids and I had a lot of fun doing it. And I had been there as a camper and I just stayed there and made a little money in the summer. And there was a guy there who studied with Barry Galbraith, who is a great guitar player, played rhythm guitar on every record you would own. He's on Clifford Brown Strings and he's on all the Tony Bennett records, and one of my father's main influences, favorite rhythm guitar players. And he was a great teacher, he had a studio in the Ed Sullivan building. And this kid Mike Tapplinger had studied with him and knew of my dad, and he met me at camp, and he said, "You're Bucky Pizzarelli's son, oh gee, we should get together and play." So I went to his house — actually he came to my house — and my father said, "you should play seven string behind him." And I said oh, okay. And he showed me a couple of little tricks. And I had already picked it up and he showed me how to play "Watch What Happens" on it. And there was not a lot of difference for me. I said oh okay, I saw what the deal was. And I started to accompany him and I got a little idea, oh okay, I see how this works. And long story short, that turned into when I came back from college I started playing duets with my dad, like I was saying like concerts, so I knew six more songs so I came up earlier in the show.

MR: I see.

JP: Sometimes we'd do the whole night together. And then one day we were doing a concert out in Morristown at a library, and he said, "Play the seven today, we'll both play sevens. This way when I solo you accompany me, and when you solo I'll accompany you, we'll have the two sevens going." Sure. So the hardest thing was playing "Chicken a la Swing" and forgetting about the other string. And it was fun. And from there on in it was two times seven.

MR: Doing more bass lines with that?

JP: Yeah. You play the chord and so if you had a D minor chord, now the bass note was an octave lower than where it would be on the regular A string because of the low A. And then you could [scats]. So the "ja" is the chord [scats]. And it was great. It was so simple and it's still — a lot of guys get too wrapped up in harmonizing the seventh string. Don't worry about it. Don't use it for anything but that kind of stuff. Playing great chord melodies and things. That's what it was for you know.

MR: Did you get to a point on a particular day or time when you said you know I'm going to make my living doing this?

JP: You know I never did. The only thing that I wanted to do I thought was to — I thought somewhere along the line a wrote a lot of pop songs and I thought maybe there was a chance along the way there was going to be some pop music in my future, of performing my own songs and being Billy Joel or James Taylor. And it's interesting you should ask that question because I never ever realized that I was making a living doing what I was — and I was playing with my dad, and I'd be getting these $600 checks and $1000 checks or whatever, $250, whereas when I was playing dances with my band, I'd be getting $25. And that was like wow. If we had $50 for the gig we were going crazy. And I still had the rock band, because we had fun doing it, and we'd have stretches of down time and I was playing solo gigs and then on the week-end I'd take a rock gig with my band, just playing four chord songs, three chord songs. And my father said, "you're the only guy playing jazz to support his rock & roll habit." And he was right. I mean I'd be playing gigs and I'd be giving the money away. Ah we're having fun here, Doug had the van, give Doug the gas money, I'll take five bucks and I'll have another beer. And the drummer, he had to come alone, give him the toll money.

MR: What was your repertoire at the time? CCR and that kind of stuff?

JP: No it was more Beatles. We did all the Beatles covers. So we did "Slow Down," "Dizzy Miss Lizzie," "Long Tall Sally," we did some Allman Brothers songs like "One Way Out," and we did some Little Feat tunes. It was just wild. We even played a couple of the original songs that were easy to play. And then late at night, this was like a gig we played downtown. We would just fake tunes and it was really horrible. We tried to fake "Live and Let Die," which okay, with a band, nobody knew what was going on. So we had a lot of fun. And then we'd play BeeGee's tunes, and play "More than a Woman," and I'd sing the [scats]. So we were having fun and it was a good release from just everything else. It was nice. But I mean I'd come from gigs in tuxedos with my father, concerts, and go right down. I'd finish, because we'd hit at midnight. I'd finish somewhere at 10:30 and I'd run in and my father'd be shaking his head. "I can't believe you're doing this."

MR: Wow. Did use of your vocal thing come along naturally. I know I've been reading about Nat King Cole who — it was suggested to him like, you need to start singing, or could you, and from there, it's history.

JP: Well I played in I think it was the beginning of college. Since I was already singing and playing in rock bands through high school, when I went to college I had my guitar and I had with me the Kenny Rankin album, I had some Michael Franks records, and some James Taylor stuff. And I had seen guys who sat and played the guitar, you know, folk guys. And so I learned some of these Kenny Rankin songs, like "Haven't We Met" and he did "Here's that Rainy Day," and he did "Sunny Gets Blue" on this one record. And then I learned some Michael Franks songs. And when I came home from college in 1980, this kid I went to high school with sang like Dick Haymes, and he looked like Dick Haymes. And his father found my father and he said, "my kid's gotta be with your kid" they gotta put them together. And he got us a gig in his favorite restaurant in Tappan, New York on a Monday night, sitting in the corner, he bought the kid a PA and a mic and he basically got me. So for eighty bucks, forty apiece, we sat in the corner and he sang all the Dick Haymes and Sinatra songs, and we would have a little rehearsal and I'd play seven string and accompany him, and then he'd say, "okay sing something." And I'd sing "Popsickle Toes" or "Here's That Rainy Day." And his sister, this is the official story now, you're the only one, I've got time right, all right, his sister had a record of a guy named Frank Weber, it was of pop songs, good pop songs. And one of the songs Frank Weber covered was "Straighten Up and Fly Right." And she said, "oh you should do this tune." So I learned it off the Frank Weber record and I played it for my father. And he said, "that's the old Nat Cole song. Jeez, "he said, you've got to get all his stuff, they're perfect songs for you." Because I wasn't singing "Night and Day." So at that very time, I know it sounds goofy, but I found Capitol records releases "The Best of the Nat King Cole Trio" Part one and two. And I go my God, boom. I walk home, I'll never forget it, gray sky, it was like January, I said, "I've got 'em." He said, "put 'em on, sit down." "Paper Moon" was the first one. And he sat there and he almost sang the entire record. My father sang the whole record to me. He was singing [scats] the whole record, right down. "All right, put on 'Body and Soul.'" "Body and Soul," sang the entire Oscar Moore chorus to me. And then, "Here comes, listen when Nat goes" [scats], and my eyes were like this. And then I heard all that "Sweet Lorraine" "Baby, Baby All the Time," "Gee Baby Ain't I Good to You," I learned all the songs. And I said now that, that's music. That's something I can do. It's all there. Great jazz, the songs are singable, and I just wrapped myself around that. I've got to get me more of that stuff. And so when I went on gigs, duo gigs with my dad, we'd do about, in an hour concert say, we'd do 25

minutes and he'd say "sing, sing something." And he'd say — and I'd do "Straighten Up and Fly Right," "For Sentimental Reasons." And then we would close out. We would do an Ellington medley and "Sing Sing Sing" or a little Goodman medley. And so as luck would have it, it's amazing, it's weird thinking about it because it's so long ago to me now. In 1983, in May of '83 I was singing this tune "I Like Jersey Best." A buddy of mine wrote this song about our state, make a little rock & roll record with my friend singing it, because he brings me the song. A guy named Phil Bernardi brings the song to me. The guy who wrote it is Joe Cosgriff. He meets my sister at *Newsweek* magazine and says, "I got this song," long story shorter, "I got this song, I want to play it for your dad," he brings over Phil, his friend, to our house. They sit and play "I Like Jersey Best" for us. Great. We want to make a record, where can we go? Well there's a place in Allendale, a guy had in his basement a little four track studio, we made this "I Like Jersey Best" record. That's 1980. And I'm singing it on gigs now with Bucky. He says, "sing that Jersey song, I love that." I sing the Jersey song, and in 1983 they want to make a record of me singing. And me and Johnny Hartman, not together, but for Stash Records. And there's a guy named Lou Ginsberg who is a friend of my dad's whose been following us all around, whose going to put up the money for my record. Why I don't know, he's just a fan, he's got some money, he wants to hear me sing this song. So Johnny Hartman gets sick. He's supposed to make the record, they have the studio booked and Tony Monte, a good friend of mine who was going to play piano for Johnny says "Johnny can't do it." He says, "He's got a little flap in his throat, it's not right." So Bernie Brightman calls and says, "I've got studio time on Wednesday. So why don't you bring him in and we'll make the record right away." So like this is Monday. So I'm going okay we'll do "Route 66," "Straighten Up and Fly Right," "Sentimental Reasons." I also had found Dave Frishberg so I learned "I'm Hip." And my father had some old scratchy Joe Mooney records so I did "Man with a Million Dollars," and "Have Another One Not Me," and "I Like Jersey Best." So I go in the studio, I sit in the booth, there's Russ Kassoff on piano, Jerry Bruno on bass and my father, the Pierre Trio, the Pierre Hotel trio where he was working. And they accompany me and I sing and it comes out and they had a big party and Peggy Lee came to the party and it was this really wild scene. And WNEW here in town starts playing the record and now all of a sudden I'm on the radio and I'm a vocalist. It wasn't any conscious effort to say be a singer, it was just part of what I was doing to make a living. I was singing and playing in bars, or in restaurants. And so — I'm doing the right thing, like talking about this, right?

MR: Yeah.

JP: I might be rambling you know. I never am allowed to talk this much. And still I do. But it was one of those things. I mean this song became a sort of little hit, this "I Like Jersey Best" thing and then like a year later Stash said, "let's make another record." So I made another record and Dave McKenna was in town. I said, "well let's get McKenna, and we'll get Butch Miles and Jerry Bruno played bass, and we did half with them and my dad, some more Nat King Cole things "This Will Make You Laugh," "Hit That Jive Jack," and then with my friend Steve Ferrera on drums and Gary Haase on bass, we did "Haven't We Met," we made like a little sort of rock record of "Racing With the Moon" with a little backbeat, and did some more original songs and that came out. And that's all been re-released sort of on CDs along the way. And I made one more for Stash. And so the records got reviewed and I was just working with my dad from 1980 to 1989 we worked everywhere and anywhere — house parties, concerts, we would play clubs out in Jersey, The Cornerstone out in New Jersey in Metuchen and nobody would listen, everybody would be talking away you know, and we'd sit and play for two hours, just talking to each other. "Okay what do you want to play, okay," boom.

MR: Yeah. You're getting paid to rehearse.

JP: Ear training 101 too. Well we'll fake that song, okay, and he'd play melodies. And the best example of that is my first gig with my dad was eight weeks at the Pierre Hotel in 1980, the summer of 1980. July and August. And the first night I knew about eight songs. And if I only knew, we had to play four hours. And I remember him saying "Mountain Greenery." "What?" And he'd go [scats] and he'd look at me and he'd be pounding these melodies out, and wouldn't tell me anything. And maybe once in a while he'd hit a G7 like you didn't hear G7? Oh, and it was the longest eight weeks. But I mean I learned, started to learn songs. And it was the best — I figured it out along the way that the way he learned was by watching Joe Mooney at Sandy's when he was twelve. He'd go down on Sundays with his uncles and watch Joe Mooney rehearse at this club in Paterson. And Joe Mooney was blind and he had the accordion with Andy Fitzgerald on clarinet and Jack Hotop on guitar and Gate Frega. And they'd be playing and Joe would say, "here's how it goes," and he'd go [scats] and here's what you play, and this is what you play. And that's how he taught me. He'd go zip, zip, zip and that's what you'd do. And then he'd say, "let's fake this tune." Rehearsals — there was never written out music. And it's the best thing, and it was the hardest thing.

MR: Was it aggravating at the time?

JP: Oh, it was just hell. I mean I was angry for the whole time, and I'd say stupid things to my father, like, "all right already." You know I was just grinding my teeth you know. And I sang too at that time. I got a nice review in the *Times*. John Wilson came down and

reviewed us. But it was really hard. It's still hard. And I used to say to him every once in a while, "could maybe you — could just call the chords out?" You know, "there's a chord you want to hear, could you just tell me C7? That would help." And he'd go ahhh.

MR: You sound like him.

JP: Well it's so funny. As stubborn as a mule and it just drove me up the wall. But the thing that I'm appreciative of is the fact that you watch kids, you watch these kids today. And they get that damn *Real Book* out and they open the *Real Book* up and they say okay "Body and Soul" page 6, and they're all sitting there with music stands and it makes me want to puke. That's the best word I can use. It's like get rid of the damn book. You should have these songs in your head. And that was — at least the best thing is that I know them from up here and I can fake them from up here. If somebody called a song I didn't know I can sit down and I can hear where we're going because I'm aware of — I was on a bandstand with Bob Haggart and Ralph Sutton and looking up at Bob saying "You're going to help me out here," and Bob saying, "don't worry." He just looked at me like, and he'd go boom and he'd just look at me.

MR: Yeah, give you the look.

JP: And he'd just hit them all. And you'd go oh, there they are. And you'd know if it was a D minor chord you'd hear D minor, and then you'd hear down the line D minor, C and you'd hear it all going. And you'd just sit there and he'd go, "you got it?" And he would look at me like you got it. And I'd go oh, okay. And I was so happy that he was being nice to me. And so, that was in Odessa in 1981 I think. Herb Ellis couldn't make it and my father says, "we'll take the kid, we'll take him down there." And so I found myself on these bandstands with all these guys. Milt Hinton and with Bob Haggart playing rhythm behind Bob Wilber, Carl Fontana or whoever the guys were. And there's — with the sticks — Cliff Lehman walking around with metal sticks all day. And then Red Norvo was there and I mean it was an amazing group of guys. Just shaking your head. Yank Lawson. And Scott Hamilton and Warren Vache were the new kids on the block then.

MR: Well how does a young player who doesn't have the advantage of having a father like that, do the ear thing, like you did it?

JP: Exactly. I think the best piece of advice I've tried to give when I've done the few things that I've done, clinics, I say well listen, take out the book, you don't know "Body and Soul?" Sit at home, learn "Body and Soul." When you finish learning it, take the page, rip it out, throw it out. And at the end you'll have a nice binder. You know? Teach yourself the songs. Don't take the book on the gig. Because the book is then your crutch. And then it's also like for me it's sort of like learning songs. I write them down or I type them out now, I look at the lyrics, and I put them on and I keep them out and I try to sing them

watching T.V. Or try to learn songs being disturbed by everything that's going on in the room. Because when I'm going to play there's going to be a lot of other stuff going on that's going to screw me up. So I figure if I can do it while the baby's about to light matches, and still get through the tune and memorize where I'm headed, or with the T.V. on, then I know I'm going to be cool. So I think it really is woodshedding, and it's learning all the songs and the other thing is you've got to make sure the other guys know the tunes that way. So I was lucky too. I mean with Mike Tapplinger we went through a lot of that. The hardest thing for me was, you know it's A-A-B-A, and making sure you knew that the A section is three times after you go back. You know, it's A-A-B-A-A-A-B. And we'd always, and you'd always think, is the bridge next?

MR: Right. Somebody's waiting to hit the bridge chords.

JP: And my father goes, "no it's not the bridge yet, you've got one more A section." So the best thing is I'd say learn the songs and get them in your head. Or I learned a lot of them off records too. I found good records. You know the Sinatra records are great because, especially that "Sinatra and Strings" because the bass notes are there and Costa's, Don Costa's chords to those songs, those ten songs, are so great. Bass notes and chords are all there. And he was a guitar player so it all works. So that kind of stuff. It was just a matter of finding people. You can find them, I think. I mean I was lucky. And my brother was fun to be around because he was amenable to the same thing.

MR: What do you think of the kind of codified thing that's happened in jazz — I get some younger students who come to me with this material they've had, and they ask me well when do I use this symmetric diminished scale? And I have to say jeez, I don't even know what that is.

JP: Right.

MR: Do you think that stuff is good?

JP: I couldn't tell you a thing about it. And I think the way that I learned it was when you listen to George Barnes play, he knew the chords to the songs. And when I learned, the best thing that I learned was knowing the chords to the songs first. Because my father wouldn't let me play a solo for a year. I just played the chords. So when I went back to blow on the songs I already knew, ah, it's E flat minor 7 is the first chord, A flat, D flat, G flat, okay. So at least I could go [scats]. I mean I could know where the triads were. I just know them as the triads to the chords. And the other things was is if a guy is thinking about the scales, he never, by the time you catch the scale, the chord's gone. You know, if you're thinking oh, I can play a Lydian thing on that. By the time you learn it — well it's gone. So I guess if you're going to think about it at home and think about where all that stuff's going to work, I think it's all stuff you can use at home, when thinking about

how you're going to play on a song, or what your style is going to be. And then I think it's the same thing like the books, leave all that stuff at home. And once you're on the bandstand you're going to see where all that's going to work. And I think it's just learn by doing. The more I've been playing with the group, the more that you realize your ass is on the line every night, you know it's almost like blowing by fear. You know? It's your turn. When Zoot Sims pointed at me, on a bandstand, my father was looking at Zoot like, "no, not the kid, don't point at him." And Zoot, you know, and I was all excited you know, and I had my one song worked out. But it was like I had one chorus and I was trying to find the other choruses after a while. And I was lucky because I listened to Bucky. And Bucky played, like he knew where the chords were. We never thought of them as modes. I just think well if it's D flat chord it's whatever D flat is [scats]. And it's either major or minor. And along the way I say oh there's some neat notes in there you can play also that work. But I never thought they were a raised nine or a flat five or all that.

MR: Right. They're just tones in between.

JP: Yeah. I mean I just heard it the way I heard it, from listening to other guys play. I mean once the hand starts to know where all the little triads were, then you'd start to find other notes and you'd go ah, I see where that's at. And there were two licks my father showed me [scats]. That was one of them. And there's [scats], that was, like so on G it would be [scats]. At any rate, well it's close, I mean that was it. And he said, "ah, you can play that on a two-five." Over there, when he got to two-five, which is about as deep as we got, he goes, "you can always play 'Tea for Two' on two-five." [scats]. Or "Honeysuckle Rose" works on that too [scats]. That's where you'd find — it was all about melodies too. I mean my father, nobody plays a melody better than my father. He milks the shit out of it. You will edit this right? And I mean he does. And he plays, it's because that's what it's about. And everything else is gravy after that. He plays "Nuages" and there's nobody that plays "Nuages" like my father because he lives for that melody and everything else revolves around that.

MR: Wow. You've had, it seems like, pretty good success with record label support. I was looking at your Christmas album and I'm seeing Don Sebesky, Pat Williams, Clare Fisher.

JP: Johnny Mandel.

MR: Yeah, Johnny Mandel.

JP: This will only take 25 minutes. Talk about blessed, I mean everywhere along the way, something good happened. And so Chesky Records makes a record of Johnny Frigo and me and Bucky, Ron Carter or Michael Moore and Butch Miles playing with Johnny

Frigo, you know, a violin player. And we all sat around the mic and play acoustic jazz, and then Chesky, David and Norman Chesky, the had just started the label. They go like, "We're looking for a male singer, you know any male singers who could be on—" I said "Why don't you come hear my group?" So they'd come to the thing, they'd hear my trio up at Jay's when it used to be a great club here in New York, and I finished the set and David Chesky says, "well we're going to get Milt Hinton and Clark Terry and your dad and we'll make a record with you singing. And I'm like looking at them. Okay. And we get — McKenna's in town so we get Dave McKenna, and just for good measure we get Connie Kay on the drums. It was either Connie Kay or Mel Lewis. And God bless them both. And Mel couldn't make it so we got Connie Kay. And I'm sitting there looking at these guys, going okay, "My Blue Heaven" fellas? Yeah, sure [scats] and everybody's going to the ball game and I'm sitting — oh my God. So I'm thinking I'd better play good you know. So that record gets me to RCA, because Harry Connick was becoming a star and RCA, Steve Backer was looking for a vocalist. He comes in to see me at The Algonquin and he says, "let's get you on the label." And they come out with a decent enough budget to make a big band record with, Dick Lieb did the arrangements. We made two records, made a bunch of records, and when you're at RCA, or like Novus at the time which was a hot label, and then guys at RCA got mad that Novus was the hot label so like Steve Backer all of a sudden wasn't around anymore and there was another new guy. Well we make our way, the presidents change and a new president, a guy from Canada, Bob Jameson comes in. He gets friendly with my manager, because I say Bob Jameson loves me, he's seen me in Canada a bunch of times. Okay. Bob says let's move him up to the big label. All right I'm up on the big leagues now, it's like me and Dave Matthews on the label. And they get this guy, Ron Fair, and he says, he's like one of their rock & roll guys, a young guy, but he's like a retro guy, because that's the big word everybody's using in 1995, it's very retro, and Pizzarelli's very retro, what am I? Okay. We've got do a Christmas record with you and we'll get all the best arrangers and this way, you know because they'll play it every year, and it's a good way to introduce you to people who wouldn't listen to you because it's Christmas songs, everybody buys Christmas records. And we'll get — who do you want to get? We'll get Johnny Mandel, we'll get Ralph Burns. And I'm going is this guy serious? Okay. I went sure. They spent $250,000. I mean whatever anybody wanted, they got. They got Capitol Stude records, you know, Studios, where Nat Cole made all his records. And I'm going okay. And there's Clare Fischer, and there's John Clayton, there's Patrick Williams, there's Johnny Mandel, there's Michel Legrand and his entire French orchestra who just came in off a plane to play a concert, and that was a whole story in itself. And I'm sitting there going

okay. Aside from then having like personal troubles in my life, I'm like losing my voice, in between all of this stuff that's going on. But the record gets made. And then we go to promote it, and Sebesky, we're going to promote it at the Blue Note and Sebesky writes new chart for the band, and Ron Fair says, "well we've got to record Avalon, this is all new, we need to do that as well as" — well we were doing the Christmas in the middle of the show. We go in the studio and it's January and we record all this, because the band's hot. Great. So and there's another $100,000. Okay. It's not coming out of my pocket.

MR: Don't say anything because this might—

JP: I'm swinging. So you know, but now you ran into all the like rock & roll publicists and all that, and the review guys are saying, "oh Pizzarelli has big budget records" and he's this and he's that. And like well hey, what am I supposed to do? I'm going to make a small group record? I'm having the time of my life working with the best people, and making good records. And then, there's the fateful Beatle record. I made a Beat Meets the Beatles record, and Sebesky writes the charts and it's killing and there's strings and we had all this great stuff and all the rock & roll people at RCA said no more, no more Pizzarelli. They didn't get it. I thought, the idea was we can take our style, use Beatles music to attract people who wouldn't listen to us. And it was a blatant attempt to sell records because that's how you make a living, I always thought, you try to sell records, which reviewers always say, "he's trying to sell records."

MR: Well really.

JP: I can't remember, when was the last time we made a record for myself. But you know you're trying to get people to buy your records. So anyway, all of a sudden calls weren't returned and then, oh, talk to him, and then we made our way to Telarc, which will be our new home, and Telarc has Oscar Peterson and George Shearing and Andre Previn and Brubeck. And they were just like well, "make a record, go ahead, have some fun, we'll bring your trio in and record your trio." Great. And it's just that I always managed to be in the right place at the right time, and Bucky Pizzarelli set me up for all that. I mean if it wasn't — there's a guy named Dick Abels who was an old friend, a gopher, he used to run around New York and find — he found the Chesky's and he'd find the Stash record labels and we were in their office, you know like in a crowded office playing our guitars for these guys and they'd be going okay we'll record ya. You know. And that's — the Bucky Pizzarelli mentality was we go and do, we'll go get 'em, we'll find 'em somewhere. And so just all along the line just trying to improve what I did, sing better, play better, and just try to get it out there. And I was lucky, people said they wanted to spend $100,000, great. Let's make a great record. And when you look back in twenty years at "Our Love is Here To Stay" and the Christmas record and the Beatles record,

they stand up against all the records, I mean they're just as good as anything that's been made on that subject to date. They're intelligent records. Whether or not they sell four copies or 400,000 copies, I thought they were well made, well recorded, they had a lot of class and they're like — I have a pretty good library at RCA. And now it's going to only get better I think. But I've always thought that marketability and marketing was important too, to making records. And so I've told RCA, I've told Telarc, I'm in town, in Boston, send me to wherever you want to send me, I'll go to like a bakery and play. Wherever it's going to help you sell my records. And because of the seven string guitar I can go on radio programs. And I was in Canada a couple of months ago. And I brought the guitar and he said, "well we're going to play some re—" I said I brought the guitar, I'll sing, I'll sit here and sing. "You're kidding?" No. Boom. You know. And so all that stuff, that's Bucky Pizzarelli. "We'll take the guitars down and we'll go play for 'em." You know, that' kind of thing. So-and-so's sick, we'll go over and play for him at the house. And I think Telarc's going to figure that out. I don't think RCA figured it out. That's what it takes, is that I don't think a lot of jazz guys can do that as well as I can.

MR: Yeah. You've got to be willing to promote yourself.

JP: Yeah. And then I think I can talk too much, and I've got a little bit of a personality that says you know, you want to turn the cameras on, I can do all that. And I did radio programs and I've done all sorts of stuff that have really helped the other aspects of what it's about to try and sell records. And I never compromised what I did. I mean I thought the Beatles record was not a compromise in that we were playing the way we play. We never did anything we weren't supposed to do.

MR: Well I have a quote here from you.

JP: Uh oh.

MR: Uh oh. It says, "I think the idea that you have to accommodate younger ears with younger sounds is just fiction, totally untrue." 1987.

JP: Wow. That's pretty smart.

MR: Yeah, well said.

JP: Well I think that's what I told them, what I've been telling, I told RCA. I said, and if you look at it it's obvious. Natalie Cole did not change — I mean she sang with Nat but they sang the Nat arrangement. Harry Connick had a big band and went around the world with it. And they were going ding-ding-a-ding. And Tony Bennett went on MTV and he went ding-ding-a-ding. They're not stupid. People aren't stupid. And that was the point, was I'm playing "Avalon" and I'm playing these fierce guitar solos and it sounds great and there's no reason that a 17-year-old is not going to like that any better than — you know they were like, "be cool, wow." I go to my friend's high school to talk to the kids. And I

play "Avalon" by myself. And the kids are looking at me like where did he come from? They would have loved Joe Pass doing that same thing. If Joe Pass went in and did that for 17 year olds they'd go crazy. Or Tal Farlow. And so I always said you can get it to them. You don't have to put me in a weird outfit and jeans and tell me not to wear a tie because they're all — the tie, you know, you shouldn't be wearing a tie and you shouldn't be smiling God forbid. Nobody cares about that in the end. It's about the music. It's like it's the economy stupid. And that's what they want to hear. They want to hear great music. If you bring it to them they're going to take it. You don't have to go heyyy, here they come. Just take it. Bring it to them.

MR: What's your feeling about the marketing today of pop music and MTV? Does it strike you one way or the other, about what kids are exposed to?

JP: Yeah I mean I still think that honestly, there's room for a variety show of some sort. I don't think it all has to be about 18 to 35. Because 18 or 49 can do the same thing, can coexist. And I think when you look at the early "Saturday Night Lives" they had Miles Davis and they had Preservation Hall Jazz Band and they had Wynton Marsalis, and they were eclectic. They brought just as much rock & roll as they did jazz or folk or whatever. And I think that's the part of what that statement is about too, and I think I get a little tired, I mean I'm getting older now, and I'm starting to realize that when I go into HMV it's the same music. That everybody sounds the same. It's the same angst-ridden girl singer. And it's the same four guys singing about you girl. All right already. I understand. How about just once we put on Count Basie and played him just as loud? That's my dream actually is when the other car pulls up with the loud music that I just hit "April in Paris" on my CD player, or "Whirly Bird." Say oh yeah? Dig this. I'll blow your speakers right out. It's just as heavy. And it's just as rock & roll. And so Preacher John. But I mean I think it takes — somebody is going to figure it out. Maybe never, but I mean I still believe that somebody along the line will go why don't we have a half hour show at 9:00 on a cable station that says here's Clark Terry? And then here's Wallace Roney or here's John Pizzarelli or here's Diana Krall. And in a way it just says well they're going to play music for seven minutes, not three. Not at the end of a show and then get them off. I mean I think people would like that. There's a way to do it, it's just we haven't figured out how to do it and how to like do it so that you can do it economically. That's the other thing about how are we going to do it. You know you've got two cameras. If you had two cameras and a little sound board and you had Diana Krall and you figured it out, you could do it. I don't think it's that hard.

MR: If we came back and did an interview in 15 years from now, have you got goals you hope to accomplish that you can define? Or is it just keep making the best records you can?

JP: Yeah I think the goal, it sounds stupid, is less gigs more money. I mean I would love to just be able to have a little more organization to what I do. I think, I mean that's just what I'd like to do. I like doing what I do, I just like to be able to plan a little better. You know, be able to say well we always do this, when the record comes out we go here and here. And I think I've been lucky to have good people writing for me. When we are able to do pops concerts with symphonies around the world and we do big band concerts, we can play with the trio in clubs, we play concert halls. I love all of that. I think that we're able to be termed as a cabaret act when we have to be, or a jazz act at a jazz club, or whatever they want, to crooner boy, whatever you want. We're never not doing what we don't normally do. We just go out there and play "I Got Rhythm." And I think in 15 years, I think that would be the goal, to say that we're still doing that and we're at better places and we're just bringing our music out there and hopefully more people are enjoying it.

MR: Right. It's nice to see a group that has had a personnel, a group of people that have been together for a while.

JP: Oh that's the key.

MR: You know because too often you go to the clubs even and you pay quite a bit of money to get in and you're looking at good musicians, but it's not a band. And sometimes you feel a little bit, well this is personal, sometimes I feel a little bit cheated when I'm looking over and I'm seeing somebody tell chord changes to somebody.

JP: Yeah. Oh I mean I think it's hard. Harry Allen is one of my dearest friends. He's a great tenor saxophone player. And he'll go out and work with Bill Charlap and Kenny Washington and Peter Washington, and I know he lives and dies by his book. He goes around the world and plays with like a drummer and a bass player somewhere in England, and luckily he's got Charlap and they have a bit of a vibe. But I know he's got to put out those charts and you know everybody's got to know what they're doing. But actually Bill's been pretty good with them, but I mean it's a hard thing to be one guy and have to — you're not going to get Bill Charlap all over the world. So at least Bill can sort of go okay, I see where you're headed, and sort of go like that and you know you're going to hear everything come out right. But I'm struggling to keep the group together just because that's the key. I mean Diana Krall, we have talked about that too, is that she's had to change personnel. And it's hard to have two guys who know the book on the guitar. And to find guys that can play rhythm guitar. She says they don't know songs. And does anybody play any time? It's just about getting up there and swinging hard. And nobody wants to do that. It's square. It's not this it's not that. So I'm very lucky to have Ray Kennedy and Martin. Well Martin, he has to do it, there's no other option for Martin. But that's the key. I mean we go anywhere. We've got about 150, 200 things in our

brains. We just go zip, zip and it works. So I agree with you about groups, to make a long story longer.

MR: Yeah. You've got a family now, and do you find the traveling a little harder?

JP: Yeah. Especially with my son. I'm divorced from obviously my first wife. And I have a daughter by my second wife now. And so I see my son when I'm in town. And everything, there's always something going on when I'm in town so it's very hard to try and make time and go and do. And luckily he lives a block and a half from me, which only happened in the last two years, so you're able to leave the room, walk down and there he is. So that's the other reason why less gigs more money is a priority. You know I'd like to see that part, to be able to at least say let's take off July, or two weeks in July and be able to know that — my kids are off in the summer. And then have a week off at Christmas. You know I like working and I know that's what you've got to do. So to be able to plot it out better is the key.

MR: Let me play one — They used to call this the blindfold test.

[audio interlude]

JP: That's the Vineyard Concert, right?

MR: That's right. Do you listen to your own records?

JP: Oh yeah.

MR: I could almost tell you could, from what you were saying before.

JP: Oh yeah. This one in particular, it's not one of my favorites. I mean we were playing together every night.

MR: Whoa.

JP: Yeah. That's what I used to do a lot. I used to think I was having fun dropping beats. That was — my Bill Evans friends used to make me screw the time up all the time. But the best one is "Contrasts" I think. And we never got something that was representative of what we were doing for those ten years. But I think "Contrasts," the newest one that we made for Arbors, which is just the two of us, came out last year, is more of us both as musicians. This is more Bucky's leader and I do what I do. But it's funny to hear because some nights were really, really wild. There were some nights in Boston or somewhere, wherever we were, in Washington, DC, where we would play and just tear the joint up you know. And sometimes I hear it as not as perfect as I thought it was. I always listen to the duets and say I wish it was a little more — my father always says I'm fearless, so I'm always out on the end charging ahead, making mistakes and always fucking up, and he's out there, I know he's just thinking what's he doing. And he's playing his ass off. And then like last night at the Regency, he came out and played this chord thing, he plays "Stars in Your Eyes." And he plays it and you sit there and you go there's nobody doing

that. And then he started to play "Nuages" and he's looking at me like, "you going to play now?" I'm going I ain't going to play. You play. You go. You play. You're on. And he's best when he's been playing over a long period of time. Like when you hear his group with John Bunch and Jay Leonhart, that's the only group I want to go hear. And they don't play any songs that anybody else in playing. I mean they're playing "Shakey Breaks The Ice" from the Joe Mooney group, they're playing Fritz Kreisler, swinging the shit out of Fritz Kreisler tunes [scats]. And you're going okay. That's intelligent music. That's what it's about. That's what the whole magilla is about, finding songs like that and making magic. But I'm rambling now.

MR: I like your rambling.

JP: I hope I can do this again.

MR: Well we will.

JP: Did I miss anything?

MR: No, I think we covered it pretty well.

JP: I can go over my childhood again.

MR: I like to think of you playing, where you are now and think of you where you are, plugging into the same amplifier, playing the high school dances. I think that's great. You've come a long way I guess.

JP: Well it's funny that I never knew how to work the equipment then, and I don't know how to work it now. I remember Les Paul touching the ground switch of our amplifier once at the house, and I was thinking it's going to like blow up. What's he doing? Click, click, click. What is that? What is a ground switch? And all that stuff. I didn't know what any of it was. I'm watching all those guys play, and, you know, Les and Zoot Sims and all those guys and I'm thinking okay, and not knowing who they were.

MR: And then later on — whoa, this guy was in my living room.

JP: Slam Stewart was sitting on my couch, playing the bass after dinner with us, sitting around, and we were just [scats]. Okay. And he played with Art Tatum. You didn't realize any of that. And then he's gone. Shit. I had one conversation with him. I asked about Nat King Cole. Well what did you think? And he went, "well, he was something. He was a good piano player, yeah. And one day he started singing." And I'm thinking yeah. And then he went, "and that was it." And that was the story. Thanks Slam. My moment of greatness. And I used to sit up with him, because he'd come in because he stayed at our house because he lived in Binghamton. And he'd come home with my dad from Marty's, they worked at Marty's two weeks. And he'd have Ovaltine and cookies. And I'd just sit there and watch him eat the cookies. And everybody went to bed and I'd hang out with him and he'd always laugh because Zoot Sims called Ovaltine "knock out

drops" because it made him go to sleep, drinking Ovaltine and he'd go to bed. He'd drink and he'd just go "Yeah, knock out drops."

MR: Great. Well listen, thanks for your time.

JP: I appreciate it. Thank you for waiting for me.

MR: I will see you tonight.

JP: Yeah, come on by. You too. Thanks a lot. See you in 15 years.

MR: All right.